

In The Twinkling Of An Eye

"In a moment, in the twinkling of an eye....we will be changed."

I don't know about you, but sometimes it seems that my life moves so slowly, especially when I am working through a particularly painful issue. Much of our internal psycho - social - spiritual processes are just that, processes. The internal movements and shifts take time. Often, we can struggle with something for years.

Those of you who have done any long term physical or emotional therapy understand this. Those of you who have invested in spiritual direction also know this truth. We are people of process. Little by little, two steps forward - one step back, bit by bit by bit, we change. It is often long and arduous work.

On the other hand, many of us are also familiar with the swiftness of devastating change. One moment life is fine, and the next we have a stroke (or we learn that our mother has suffered a stroke). An automobile accident, a violent crime such as rape or robbery, the discovery of a severe illness, or the news that our spouse (partner) is leaving us - all delivered in an instant - can change our entire world. Our existence on this planet, and our lives as we know them, are fragile.

I was reminded of this fragility recently. A co-worked passed on a reading she had found on the Internet. It was entitled "An Interview With God." I generally do not like these things. In this one, some person has put together a number of favorite sayings and bits of advice and passed it off as the wisdom of God - given to human kind through the world wide web. There is some arrogance in claiming that these are the words God would speak in an interview.

This particular piece had two pithy remarks I found disturbing. Each was presented as something God would like us all to learn. The first was "to learn that it takes years to build trust, and a few seconds to destroy it." The second was "to learn that it only takes a few seconds to open profound wounds in persons we love, and that it takes many years to heal them." Now, I won't dispute the veracity of these statements. Sadly, it is true that we can do incredible damage in the blink of an eye. Yet, to do this much harm to a relationship so quickly and easily implies that there have already been compromises to the integrity of those relationships.

These statements also would keep us forever on eggshells. Forever vigilant that we use care and caution lest we destroy what goodness we have. At any second, we could bring irreparable ruin to those we love. Fearful and alert, for destruction could happen in a second - any second.

This perspective is one sided. Isn't it also true that great health, healing and humor can happen in the twinkling of an eye? Yes, our lives can be eternally altered in flash - but it need not be negative. Perhaps I could have tolerated this "Interview With God" better if one of the lines had instead read that humans were "to learn to watch for the minute miracles that can heal within a few seconds wounds which have been tender for years." This would seem more like a statement from God.

We can all receive, and all be the catalyst for, instances of healing, blessing and miracles. The world is full of bursts of goodness. It is our job to watch for them.

A big part of our faith is about watching for grace. Grace is that unmerited favor that comes from the universe. We do not earn it, we need only to receive it. And a big part of being spiritual people is to learn to watch for the handiwork of the Holy that is all around us. If it is grace, if it is healing, if it goodness freely given, then we know that it is a sign of the Holy working in our lives.

A favorite author of mine, Rachel Naomi Remen, tells of such time: (Kitchen Table Wisdom - 246-247)

At twenty-nine, much of my intestine was removed surgically and I was left with an ileostomy. A loop of bowel opened on my abdomen and an ingeniously designed plastic appliance, which I remove and replace every few days, covers it. Not an easy thing for a young woman to live with. While this surgery had given me back much of my vitality, the appliance and the profound change in my body made me feel hopelessly different, permanently shut out of the world of femininity and elegance. At the beginning, before I could change my appliance myself, it was changed for me by nurse specialists called enterostomal therapists. These white-coated professionals would enter my hospital room, put on an apron, a mask and gloves and then remove and replace my appliance. The task completed, they would strip off all this protective clothing. Then they would carefully wash their hands. This elaborate ritual made things harder for me. I felt ashamed.

One day a woman about my age came to do this task. It was late in the day and she was not dressed in a white coat, but in a silk dress, heels, and stockings. In a friendly way she asked if I was ready to have my appliance changed. When I nodded, she pulled back the covers, produced a new appliance, and in the most simple and natural way imaginable removed my old one and replaced it, without putting on gloves. I remember watching her hands. She had washed them carefully before she touched me. They were soft and gentle and beautifully cared for. She was wearing a pale pink nail polish and her rings were gold.

I doubt that she ever knew what her willingness to touch me in such a natural way meant to me. In ten minutes she not only tended my body, but healed my wounds and gave me hope. What is most professional is not always what is most healing.

"In moment, in the twinkling of an eye....we will be changed." What power there can be in authentic contact. How much good can be done in the most casual of instances.

Perhaps you have a story in your own life of someone's informal action doing untold good.

There are other ways that remedy and restoration can happen in a flash. One of the most common is humor. How often have we experienced humor as a vehicle to change our perspective or as a means to granting us courage and grace?

In his book *Oops! Or Life's Awful Moments*, radio and television personality Art Linkletter relates how he used humor in one of the greatest public catastrophes that ever occurred to him. He was to speak before a very large audience that was gathered together for one of the first Emmy Award programs televised coast to coast. Just as he said, "Good evening, Ladies and gentlemen," the master light switch exploded, leaving everyone in total darkness. He reports "Stagehands began running in all directions, knocking the entire Grecian set down. Walls, pillars, and great facades tumbled onto the orchestra. One entire section of strings was knocked out by an enormous pillar." With time to think, when the lights returned, Linkletter slowly surveyed the wreckage and then announced, "For an encore, ladies and gentlemen, we will now set fire to Lucille Ball."

Nothing but a small and silly phrase, "For an encore, we will now set fire to Lucille Ball." Still, those few words served to turn a calamity into a more manageable event. Some equilibrium was restored.

There are also times when we reach an impasse. The world, our situation, the stress, becomes more than we can negotiate. We become frozen. We do not know where to turn and even if we did, we do not know how to go on. Again, humor can be an instant miracle.

I always liked the story that... At one point during the Cuban missile crisis, Soviet and American negotiators became deadlocked. There they sat in silence, until someone suggested that each person tell a humorous story. One of the Russians told a riddle: "What is the difference between capitalism and communism?" The answer? "In capitalism, man exploits man. In communism, it's the other way around." The tactic worked; with the mood relaxed, the talks continued.

(Allen Klein - The Healing Power of Humor)

A little riddle, a little silliness, a big difference - in only a moment.

But what about the matters in our own lives? Most of us are not going to deal with a cataclysmic event on national television. I rather doubt many of us will be in such a touchy situation as sitting at the negotiations table for a missile crisis. However, we each have pains and heartaches and emergencies and predicaments within our own lives. And a bit of fun can bring profound change.

In *Humor: God's Gift*, pastor Tal Bonham talks about how some nonsense helped break the ice between his wife, who had been hospitalized for severe depression, and some of her friends. He writes:

Depression! I secretly wondered if my wife would ever laugh again... As we drove home from the hospital that day she looked into the mirror and exclaimed, "Yuk, I look like a witch!" (My apologies to any witches out there for the stereotype.)

"A visit to the beauty shop will do wonders for you," I suggested. "But if you insist," I said, "I'll tell your friends when they call that you've emerged successfully from the hospital except for one problem."

"And what is that?" she asked.

"I'll tell them that you think you're a witch and that you ride a broomstick around the house!"

She laughed. "Why don't you?" she asked.

"Are you serious?"

"Yes, maybe it'll break the ice a little bit. People never seem to know just what to say to someone with emotional problems." she explained. Later that evening, one of her friends called and asked if she and another friend might come over to see Faye.

"Come right on over," I said.

"Well, how is she?" asked her friend. "Are there any aftereffects?"

"Only one," I explained deliberately and compassionately. "You see, she recovered well from the treatments except for periodic spells when she thinks she's a witch."

"She thinks she's a witch!" her friend yelled into the phone.

"Yes, from time to time, she'll jump up, run to the kitchen, get the broom, and ride it across the room. It doesn't last long. I suggest, if she has a spell while you are here, that you just remain calm and act as though nothing is happening."

Later in the evening, Faye's friends came laden with gifts of perfume and, thankfully, much food. I could tell that it was difficult for Faye to talk about her stay in the hospital. Then, I noticed a gleam in her eye as she got up from the sofa in the den and walked to the kitchen.

She was going to do it!

Her friends were sitting with their backs to the kitchen, and I was facing them. As Faye mounted her broom, she smiled at me like a child about to take the lid off the cookie jar to steal a cookie.

"Giddy up!" she called as she rode the broom from the kitchen, made a U turn in the den in front of her friends, and galloped back to the refrigerator. Their eyes followed every stride as she deposited her faithful steed in the kitchen corner. They kept talking about something else, but their eyes and their minds were focused on Faye and her broom. When she returned to the sofa, her friends were strangely silent and seemed to have nothing more to say. When we finally explained our little plan to break the ice, we all laughed boisterously and enjoyed a delightful evening of conversation thereafter.

"In a moment, in the twinkling of an eye....we will be changed." To me, this is grace, in the fullest religious sense of the word. Grace refers to the free and unmerited acts through which we are restored to goodness (or

to God). A gift, a new chance, another start, freely presented in the ridiculous image of a woman riding her kitchen broom around her house.

But there is more. We can be changed in an instant by a shift in perspective. There are some shifts in the way we view a situation which are helpful and pleasant. I think of these as "re-framing." Some event is disturbing to us or we begin to trap ourselves in worrying thoughts and feelings of fear. Then, whether on our own or with the encouragement of a friend, we are able to look at the matter in a new light, from a different angle. An upcoming session with our boss may transform in our eyes from an anxious encounter to an opportunity to honestly communicate. A hurtful comment uttered by a neighbor may become a humorous misunderstanding. How things look depends on where we stand. And a shift in perspective can make all the difference.

As a matter of fact, religious conversion involves such a shifting. According to William James in *The Varieties of Religious Experience*, conversion is often the replacement of one world view for another. Sometimes these conversions happen in a moment and life is never the same.

Yet I am thinking of smaller changes of perspective, which can still have a lifetime of impact. A phrase someone says to you, a thought read in a book, an idea forming in your mind, can instantly make a difference in who we are and how we live.

Rabbi Jeffrey Salkin gives us an example of this in his book *Being God's Partner*:

A few years ago, a young taxi driver drove me to John F. Kennedy airport on Long island. After a few minutes of conversation, I discovered that Mike had belonged to my synagogue years before I came to the community.

"So, Rabbi," he asked while we sat in heavy traffic, "what do you say to a Jew like me who hasn't been in a synagogue since his bar mitzvah ceremony?"

Thinking for a moment, I recalled that in Hasidic lore, the ball aqalah (the wagon driver) is an honored profession. So I said, "We could talk about your work."

"What does my work have to do with religion?"

"Well, we choose how we look at the world and at life. You're a taxi driver. But you are also a piece of the tissue that connects all humanity. You're taking me to the airport. I'll go to a different city and give a couple of lectures that might touch or help or change someone. I couldn't have gotten there without you. You help make that connection happen.

"I heard on your two-way radio that after you drop me off, you're going to pick up a woman from the hospital and take her home. That means that you'll be the first non-medical person she encounters after being in a hospital. You will be a small part of her healing process, an agent in her re-entry into the world of health.

"You may then pick up someone from the train station who has come home from seeing a dying parent. You may take someone to the house of the one that he or she will ask to join in marriage. You're a connector, a bridge builder. You're one of the unseen people who make the world work as well as it does. That is holy work. You may not think of it this way, but yours is a sacred mission."

A change. From taxi driver to one with a sacred mission. It seems a much better way to spend one's day - helping to build connections - than merely driving a taxi.

We can also be transformed in the ways we view others and in the ways we understand their actions. That old cliché "Walk a mile in your neighbor's shoes" can make all the difference in our attitude and feelings. What was confusing may become clear. What was awful may become tolerable. What was uncomfortable may lead to compassion.

There is a story (Buddhist educator) Sharon Salzberg tells from her book *Lovingkindness*:

I handed my passport to a uniformed Soviet official. He looked at my picture, and he looked at me, and he looked at my picture, and he looked at me. The look he gave me was, I think, the most hateful stare I have ever received from anybody in my life. It was an icy rage. It was the first time in my life that I had experienced that kind of energy so directly and personally. I just stood there, shocked. Finally, after quite a long period of time, the official handed me back my passport and told me to go.

I went to the transit lounge of the airport, where my traveling companions were waiting for me. I was very upset. I felt as though the man's energy had poisoned my being. I had absorbed his hatred, and I was reacting strongly to it. Then, in one moment, everything shifted. I thought, "If being exposed to his energy could make me feel so terrible after ten minutes, what would it be like to live inside that energetic vibration all the time?" I realized that this man might wake up, spend much of the day, and go to sleep in a state quite similar to the one I had just experienced from him. A tremendous feeling of compassion came into me for him. He was no longer a threatening enemy, but rather someone in what seemed to be intense suffering.

How quickly and how marvelously we can be touched. Something small and simple can make the biggest difference. Its impact can last for years. Sometimes for the rest of our lives.

Rather than live our lives as though at any second we could cause tremendous harm, wouldn't it seem more in tune with the Mystery to live our lives watchful for instant and powerful restorations.

Let me tell you one more story. This comes from No Enemies Within by Dawna Markova.

When I was in the hospital, the one person whose presence I welcomed was a woman who came to sweep the floors with a large push broom. She was the only one who didn't stick things in, take things out, or ask stupid questions. For a few minutes each night, this immense Jamaican woman rested her broom against the wall and sank her body into the turquoise plastic chair in my room. All I heard was the sound of her breath in and out. It was comforting in a strange and simple way. My own breathing calmed. Of the fifty or so people that made contact with me in any given day, she was the only one who wasn't trying to change me.

One night she reached out and put her hand on the top of my shoulder. I'm not usually comfortable with casual touch, but her hand felt so natural being there. It happened to be one of the few places in my body that didn't hurt. I could have sworn she was saying two words with each breath, one on the inhale, one on the exhale: "As ...Is ...As... Is..."

On her next visit, she looked at me. No evaluating, no trying to figure me out. She just looked and saw me. Then she said simply, "You're more

than the sickness in that body." I was pretty doped up, so I wasn't sure I understood her; but my mind was just too thick to ask questions.

I kept mumbling those words to myself throughout the following day. "I'm more than the sickness in this body." I remember her voice clearly. It was rich, deep, full, like maple syrup in the spring...

I reached out for her hand. It was cool and dry. I knew she wouldn't let go. She continued, "You're not the fear in that body. You're more than that fear. Float on it. Float above it. You're more than that pain." I began to breathe a little deeper, as did when I wanted to float in a lake. I remembered floating in lake George when I was five, floating in the Atlantic Ocean at Coney Island when I was seven, floating in the Indian Ocean off the coast of Africa when I was twenty-eight. Without any instruction from me, this Jamaican guide had led me to a source of comfort that was wider and deeper than pain or fear.

It's been fifteen years since I've seen the woman with the broom. I've never been able to find her. No one could remember her name; but she touched my soul with her compassionate presence and her fingerprints are there still.

"In a moment, in the twinkling of an eye....we will be changed." It is not too much to ask that we become connoisseurs of wonder-full moments. It is the essence of spirituality and religion that we become aware and awake to grace, gifts freely given to those open to receive.

It is written that "Everywhere, hands lie open to catch us when we fall." Let us give thanks for this invisible support. Instead of living our lives on eggshells, let us "learn to watch for the minute miracles that can heal within a few seconds wounds which have been tender for years."

Our invitation is to be aware and open. So much can come to us. In an authentic connection with another we can be given hope. In the absurdity of humor and the power inherent in play, we find the courage to go on. In experiencing a new perspective, we are given a new approach to life. Let us keep before us the marvel of instant transformation, big or small. Let us be open to the mystery of grace. Free and generous restoration to goodness can be ours, in a second, in any second. Let us watch for the hand of the Holy, gently and surprisingly moving in our lives. Indeed, "in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye....we will be changed.

Amen and Amen.